

Husband Headship

prc-husband-headship

Family & Discipleship · Gender Roles · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.800
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Within marriage, the husband has loving headship and the wife responds with willing submission, both in mutual love and Christ-likeness.

In plain language

Three Greek words carry this question. The husband is called the head, kephale, in Ephesians 5:23 and 1 Corinthians 11:3. The wife is told to be subject, hypotasso, in Ephesians 5:22 and 24, Colossians 3:18, and 1 Peter 3:1 and 5. The husband is commanded to love, agapao, in Ephesians 5:25, 28, and 33 and Colossians 3:19. The wording lines up with an ordered marriage, but the meaning of head is the sticking point. In Koine Greek kephale can mean the one in authority over a group, and it can also mean the source or origin, like the head of a river. The Hebrew word it usually translates in the Old Testament, rosh, carries both senses too. The verses themselves do not settle which sense Paul activates, and in 1 Corinthians 11:3 the same word also describes how God relates to Christ, which makes a bare boss-over-worker reading awkward without further qualification. Several features push against reading head as plain rank. The submission verb is in the middle voice, which points to a freely chosen self-ordering rather than coercion. The sentence just before the household code, Ephesians 5:21, tells everyone to submit to one another, and that participle grammatically controls the wife clause in verse 22 in the strongest manuscript witnesses. The husband side is not a right to command but a duty to love his wife the way Christ gave himself up for the church, and to love her as his own body, with Colossians 3:19 adding the prohibition on being embittered against her. In 1 Peter 3:7 the wife is called a joint-heir of the grace of life and the husband is told to assign her honor, so the two stand equal before God even within an ordered relationship. The lexical root of the dispute is therefore simple: a key word has two well-attested senses, and the surrounding text disciplines both senses without picking one. The pattern in the words clearly supports an asymmetric, love-shaped marriage order, but does not by itself prove the specific authority claim the proposition assumes, so the verdict is genuinely contested at the word level rather than cleanly settled in either direction.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H7218	רֹאשׁ	rosh	head	600
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapao	to love	143
G0076	Ἀδάμ	Adam	Adam	
G0435	ἄνθρωπος	aner	man	215
G1135	γυνή	gyne	woman	215
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	
G2398	ἴδιος	idios	one's own/private	117
G2776	κεφαλή	kephale	head	76

G4561	σάρξ	sarx	flesh	152
G4632	σκεῦος	skeuos	vessel	23
G4789	συγκληρονόμος	sygkleronomos	co-heir	4
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotasso	to subject	40
G5401	φόβος	phobos	fear	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Three lemmas carry the proposition. *kephale* (G2776) is predicated of the husband in Eph 5:23 and 1 Cor 11:3. *hypotasso* (G5293, middle voice) is predicated of the wife in Eph 5:22, 24, Col 3:18, 1 Pet 3:1, 3:5, Titus 2:5. *agapao* (G0025, present imperative) is commanded of the husband in Eph 5:25, 28, 33. The lemmas pattern with an asymmetric marriage ordering, but the precise force of the head metaphor is materially contested at the lexical level. *kephale* denotes the anatomical head and is extended metaphorically in Pauline epistles. LSJ records the noun's literal sense set and gives the metaphorical extension to corporate heads through later usage, while the Hebrew *rosh* (H7218) that LXX *kephale* routinely translates carries both a chief or leader sense and a beginning or front sense; the Pauline extension therefore inherits two defensible Koine readings, authority over and source or origin, that the immediate context does not decisively rank. *hypotasso* in the relevant texts is middle voice, which places the act of ordering with the subject rather than imposing it externally, and Eph 5:21 *hypotassomenoi allelois en phobo Christou* immediately precedes and grammatically governs the wife clause in v22 which has no finite verb of its own. The husband side is not a right to command but *agapate kathos kai ho Christos egapesen ten ekklesian*, with the husband told to love his wife as his own body. 1 Pet 3:7 names husband and wife *sygkleronomoi charitos zoes*, joint-heirs of the grace of life. Because the headship lemma is two-valued and the surrounding household-code grammar frames the relation as reciprocal and love-bounded, the lexical data supports an asymmetric ordering in marriage but does not by itself settle the specific authority claim the stem assumes, so the verdict is disputed rather than a clean affirm or deny.

Scripture

Eph.5.21 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Force. *hypotassomenoi allelois en phobo Christou*, submitting to one another in the fear of Christ, is a present middle participle whose plural subject is the same congregation addressed in v18 to v20. Greek manuscript witnesses divide on whether v22 even contains a separate finite verb for wives, so v22 in the strongest witnesses grammatically borrows *hypotassomenoi* from v21. This governing participle places the wife clause inside a frame of mutual subjection and is the lexical hinge for any reading that resists fixed unilateral hierarchy in the household code that follows.

Eph.5.22 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G2398 ἰδιος, G0435 ἀνὴρ

Force. *Hai gynaiques tois idiois andrasin hos to kyrio*, wives to their own husbands as to the Lord. The Greek of the strongest witnesses has no finite verb here, borrowing *hypotassomenoi* from v21, so the wife clause is grammatically chained to the mutual-submission frame. The qualifier *idiois* restricts the scope to the specific marriage bond rather than woman-to-man in general.

Eph.5.23 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G0435 ἀνὴρ, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. *hoti aner estin kephale tes gynaikos hos kai ho Christos kephale tes ekklesias, autos soter tou somatos.* The predicate *kephale* is asserted of the husband over the wife and paralleled to Christ as *kephale* of the church, then immediately qualified by *autos soter tou somatos*, he himself is savior of the body. The savior tag attaches a protective and self-giving nuance to the head image rather than a bare assertion of rank. The lexical force of *kephale* here is the crux: Koine usage attests both an authority-over sense and a source or origin sense, and this verse alone does not disambiguate.

Eph.5.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. *alla hos he ekklesia hypotassetai to Christo, houtos kai hai gynaikes tois andrasin en pantī. hypotassetai* is middle-passive present indicative, and the comparative *hos he ekklesia hypotassetai* grounds the wife pattern in the church-to-Christ analogy. The middle voice carries voluntary self-ordering, not enforced subjugation, and the *en pantī* clause sets the scope without supplying a sense of compulsion.

Eph.5.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω

Force. *Hoi andres, agapate tas gynaikas, kathos kai ho Christos egapesen ten ekklesian kai heauton paredoken hyper autēs. agapate* is present active imperative directed at husbands, qualified by the *kathos* clause that grounds the love in Christ's self-giving for the church. The husband duty is sacrificial love measured by Christ, which converts any head function into a self-spending vocation rather than a prerogative.

Eph.5.28 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω, G4983 σῶμα

Force. *houtos opheilousin kai hoi andres agapan tas heauton gynaikas hos ta heauton somata.* The body identification dissolves a strict over-under hierarchy into a one-flesh care obligation: *ho agapon ten heautou gynaika heauton agapa.* Loving the wife is loving the husband's own body, which collapses competitive interests inside the head-body figure.

Eph.5.31 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4561 σὰρξ

Force. *anti toutou kataleipsei anthropos ton patera kai ten metera kai proskollethesetai pros ten gynaika autou, kai esontai hoi duo eis sarka mian,* citing Gen 2:24. The one-flesh formula is brought into the head-body argument so that the head and the body share one *sarx*, foreclosing any reading of headship as ontological separation between a higher partner and a lower partner.

Eph.5.33 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω, G5401 φόβος

Force. *plen kai hymeis hoi kath' hena hekastos ten heautou gynaika houtos agapato hos heauton, he de gyne hina phobetai ton andra.* The summary pairs husband *agapato* with wife *phobetai* (respect, reverent regard), an asymmetric pairing of love-command and respect-response within the marriage relation rather than a command-and-obey pairing.

1Cor.11.3 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G0435 ἀνὴρ

Force. thelo de hymas eidenai hoti pantos andros he kephale ho Christos estin, kephale de gynaikos ho aner, kephale de tou Christou ho theos. The chain Christ-of-man, man-of-woman, God-of-Christ uses kephale uniformly across all three relations. Because the same lemma governs the God-Christ relation, the sense cannot be reduced to simple boss-over-subordinate without straining Christology. Whatever sense the second pair carries must also fit the third, which is exactly why kephale is lexically disputed: an authority-over reading must be qualified so that it does not subordinate the Son ontologically, and a source-of reading must be qualified so that it still carries directional ordering.

Col.3.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G0435 ἀνὴρ

Force. Hai gynaikes, hypotassesthe tois andrasin hos aneken en kyrio. hypotassesthe is present middle imperative; the qualifier hos aneken, as is fitting, bounds the obedience to what is appropriate in the Lord, not absolute. The very next verse pairs it with husbands' obligation to love and not be embittered, so the lexical pattern is asymmetric directives, not asymmetric ontology.

Col.3.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω

Force. Hoi andres, agapate tas gynaikas kai me pikrainesthe pros autas. The husband imperative is paired with a prohibition on bitterness, restraining any exercise of headship that would harm the wife. The lemma agapate echoes the Eph 5:25 frame and confirms that the husband side of the household code is love and gentleness, not command rights.

1Pet.3.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G2398 ἴδιος

Force. Homoios gynaikes, hypotassomenai tois idiois andrasin. The middle participle matches Ephesians and Colossians, with idiois again restricting scope to the marriage bond. The continuation hina kai ei tines apeithousin to logo, dia tes ton gynaikon anastrophes aneu logou kerdethesontai frames submission as missional persuasion of unbelieving husbands rather than enforced silence.

1Pet.3.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4632 σκεῦος, G4789 συγκληρονόμος

Force. Hoi andres homoios synoikountes kata gnosin, hos asthenestero skeuei to gynaikio aponemontes timen, hos kai sygkleronomois charitos zoes, eis to me egkoptesthai tas proseuchas hymon. Husbands are commanded to dwell with knowledge, assign honor to the wife as a weaker vessel, and treat her as joint-heir of the grace of life. The lemma sygkleronomos asserts equal share in salvation, which complicates any reading of headship as ontological superiority while leaving the asymmetric directive structure intact.

1Tim.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0076 Ἀδάμ

Force. Adam gar protos eplasthe, eita Heua. The temporal protos-eita pair invokes the Gen 2 creation order to ground the prior instruction. Lexically, the argument hangs on chronology of forming, not on essential rank, and the same lemma cluster appears in 1 Cor 11:8-9 with the qualification in 11:11-12 that ouk estin gyne choris andros oude aner choris gynaikos en kyrio, neither is independent of the other in the Lord. So the creation-order appeal carries asymmetric ordering but is explicitly bounded by mutual dependence in the same lemma field.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
------	----	--------	-------

Eph.5.22	Eph.5.21	tsk	2
Eph.5.22	Col.3.18	tsk	2
Eph.5.22	1Pet.3.1	tsk	2
Eph.5.23	1Cor.11.3	tsk	2
Eph.5.23	Col.1.18	tsk	1
Eph.5.25	Eph.5.28	tsk	1
Eph.5.25	Col.3.19	tsk	2
Eph.5.31	Gen.2.24	tsk	3
1Cor.11.3	1Cor.3.23	tsk	1
1Pet.3.7	Gal.3.28	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Eph.5.21 · addressed

The participle *hypotassomenoi allelois en phobo Christou*, submitting to one another in the fear of Christ, immediately precedes the household code and grammatically governs the wife clause in v22, which lacks a finite verb of its own in the strongest manuscript witnesses. The mutual-submission framing is the lexical ground for the egalitarian reading of the household code and means the wife submission is set inside a broader reciprocity. The complementarian reading takes *alleloi* here distributively rather than mutually, citing parallels where *alleloi* means some to others rather than each to each, but the simpler reading is mutual. This text constrains the verdict toward disputed.

1Pet.3.7 · addressed

The joint-heir designation *sygkleronomois charitos zoes* places husband and wife as equal recipients of grace, so any headship in the stem is bounded by spiritual co-equality and honor rather than rank superiority. The *asthenestero skeuei* reference describes relative physical vulnerability and does not name an ontological hierarchy. This constrains but does not erase the ordered pattern of asymmetric directives, contributing to the disputed verdict.

1Cor.11.3 · addressed

The lexical sense of *kephale* in this verse remains underdetermined by morphology and immediate syntax. LSJ for *kephale* records the literal anatomical sense richly attested from Homer onward and notes the Hebrew *rosh* underlying LXX usage. The Hebrew *rosh* (H7218) carries both a chief or leader sense and a beginning or front sense, and the Pauline metaphorical extension legitimately inherits either. The same Greek lemma governs the God-Christ pair in the same series, which means whichever sense is chosen must avoid ontological subordination of the Son. The verse therefore attests a *kephale* relation in marriage but does not by itself rank between authority and source, leaving the headship sense lexically disputed.

1Cor.11.11 · addressed

plen oute gyne choris andros oute aner choris gynaikos en kyrio. The *plen oute* construction explicitly limits any one-directional reading of v3 with a strong mutual-dependence claim within the same lemma field (*aner, gyne*). This is the immediate context that disciplines an unbounded authority-over reading of the *kephale* chain in v3.

Concordance traversed

G2776, G5293, G0025, G0435, G1135, G4983, G4561, G2398, G4789, G4632, H7218

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Eph5.22-verb-presence at Eph.5.22: impact minor. The strongest witnesses omit a separate finite hypotassethe in v22 and require it to be borrowed from the v21 participle. Later witnesses supply the verb. Either way the wife clause depends grammatically on v21, so the verdict on the proposition is not flipped, but the grammatical link to v21 mutual submission is strengthened in the shorter reading.

These passages fall outside the ECM 3 John CBGM sample, so collation is at shadow level. The apparatus marks in Eph 5:22 to 5:33 and 1 Pet 3 mostly concern word order and minor additions and do not flip the head, submit, or love lemmas that carry the verdict. The v22 verb variant nudges the grammar toward the mutual-submission framing of v21.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. complementarian, egalitarian

analogia scripturae invoked

complementarian: affirms · Reads kephale (G2776) in Eph 5:23 and 1 Cor 11:3 in its attested authority-over sense, drawing on Pauline parallels where Christ as kephale of the church and head over all things (Eph 1:22, Col 1:18, Col 2:10) carries a clear governance sense. Reads hypotasso (G5293) as ordered response to that headship, parallel to the church to Christ in Eph 5:24, with the middle voice marking willing but real subordination rather than coerced silence. Reads the creation-order argument in 1 Tim 2:13 (Adam protos eplasthe, eita Heua) as Pauline grounding for the household pattern in the original Genesis order, and the household codes in Col 3:18-19, Titus 2:5, and 1 Pet 3:1-6 as a consistent canonical pattern. On this reading the lemmas land directly on the stem: loving headship in the husband and willing submission in the wife, both inside the Christ-church analogy.

egalitarian: disputed · Reads kephale (G2776) in its attested source or origin sense, drawing on the Hebrew rosh (H7218) sense set that includes beginning and front, and arguing that the Christ-church figure in Eph 5:23 emphasizes Christ as source of the church's life rather than ruler over it, given the immediate qualifier autos soter tou somatos. Foregrounds the present middle participle hypotassomenoi allelois in Eph 5:21 as the governing verb of v22 and reads allelois mutually, placing the entire household code inside reciprocal subjection. Reads the love-command of Eph 5:25-29 and the joint-heir designation sygkleronomos in 1 Pet 3:7 as flattening any fixed hierarchy. Treats the household codes as Spirit-shaped accommodation to a hierarchical first-century setting and reads Gal 3:28 (ouk eni arsen kai thely, panta gar hymeis heis este en Christo lesou) as the eschatological horizon that relativizes role-based authority. On this reading the lemmas attest an asymmetric pattern but do not carry the specific authority claim the stem assumes.

The verdict turns on a single lexeme kephale (G2776), whose Koine metaphorical extension is two-valued (authority over and source or origin), and on the grammatical scope of the governing participle hypotassomenoi in Eph 5:21. Both lenses share the same morphology of the passages and read the same lemmas. They differ on which attested sense of kephale Paul activates, and on how broadly the allelois of v21 governs the household code. analogia_scripturae is the decisive move on both sides: complementarian reads from 1 Tim 2:13 and Eph 1:22 inward; egalitarian reads from Eph 5:21 and Gal 3:28 inward. The lemmas alone do not rank these moves.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Within marriage, the husband is called kephale (head) of the wife and the wife is called to hypotasso (be subject) to him, while the husband is commanded to agapao (love) the wife. The precise force of kephale, whether authority over or source or origin, and the scope of the wife response are what the lexical data must decide on the original stem.

The original stem loads the verdict with the phrases loving headship and willing submission, both in mutual love and Christ-likeness, which already presupposes a specific complementarian sense of kephale and a particular voluntariness reading of hypotasso. The neutralized form names the three Greek lexemes without resolving the contested kephale sense, so the verdict is derived on the words rather than on the framing. The verdict is assessed against the original stem and lands disputed because kephale carries two attested Koine senses and the surrounding allelois grammar plus the husband's love duty plus the sygkleronomos status do not ratify the authority sense over the source sense at the word level. Verdict unchanged from prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.21
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.22
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.25
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.3.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.3.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.3.7
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2776
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0025
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2398
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2776
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7218
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.5.21
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.5.23
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.11.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.5.22
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.5.25
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Pet.3.7

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. MACULA-Greek syntax was consulted for the kephale clause structure in Eph 5:23 and 1 Cor 11:3 and for the participle scope of hypotassomenoi in Eph 5:21, and carries CC-BY-NC-4.0, which forbids bulk redistribution, so the aggregated evidence record is not safe to publish in bulk.

Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent · complicating-unresolved